A readiness diagnostic on the USAFacts ladder: a working-group explainer

Generated by `scripts/dn020_documents_build.py` from the framework record and the cycle of record.

The bottom line

The readiness diagnostic asks, for a federal statistical agency, whether a program acting for a member of the public can reach the agency's data and the documentation that goes with it. It is sixteen checks, each one request from the least privileged client the public has, against published criteria. USAFacts' August 2026 framework is the ladder those checks now hang from: three tracks, Agentic Access, Agentic Context and Agentic Evaluation, three levels in each, with three prerequisites before any level applies. An agency climbs at its own pace, and the lowest level is worth having on its own. Across sixteen agencies on the cycle of record, eleven pass every measured check at Access I and one at Access II; on the Context track two pass at Context I and one at Context II. The rungs above these carry no check yet.

One check, end to end

Take the simplest check to follow, "The page labels itself as a dataset". It has the simplest sensor on the ladder: one request to the data page, reading what the page itself sends, following no link and visiting no other location.

Figure Four goes here. Add reports/figures/dn020/4.png to place the illustration.

Figure four. A check end to end: the question, the sensor, the reading, the state.

The question. Does the data page's own markup tell a machine that the page describes a named, described dataset? **The sensor.** The data page itself, reading the structured markup embedded in the page as it is served. The public client asks the website for the data page once and reads the structured markup in what comes back, without running any of the page's scripts. **What a pass looks like.** Every data page looked at carried markup, as served before any script runs, that declares a dataset with a name and a description (and any distribution it declares carries an access address). **The state.** The reading comes back as one of four: it passes, it partly passes, it fails, or it could not be measured and the reason is recorded. A reason is never a fail.

Where the framework comes from



Figure two. FAIR, 2016; the USAFacts guide, 2025; the USAFacts framework, 2026; and this project's sensor on the ladder.

FAIR, 2016. The FAIR principles asked that data be "Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Reusable, written so that machines as well as people can act on data". They are deliberately high level and have been read many ways.

The USAFacts guide, 2025. USAFacts' earlier guide set out four criteria, "Accessible, Understandable, Accurate, Open", written from its experience as a heavy consumer of federal data.

The USAFacts framework, 2026. In the August 2026 framework "Accessible becomes the Access track; Understandable becomes the Context track; Accurate becomes the Evaluation track; Open moves out of the ladder and becomes a prerequisite", with levels borrowed from SLSA.

This project. This project puts "the ladder with a sensor on it": each check is a measurement specification, each prerequisite is tested rather than declared, and the tracks the sensor cannot reach yet are marked as such rather than scored.

Where the sixteen checks sit on the ladder

USAFacts rung	Checks placed here
Prerequisite, discoverable	The data page is in the site's list of pages; The page labels itself as a dataset; The product is listed in the agency's data inventory
Prerequisite, clearly licensed	The terms of reuse, under a recognised name
Access I	Data offered as a file a program can read; The whole dataset in one download; Whether the site's visitor rules let AI tools in; The interactive data tool answers honestly; What the site states about

USAFacts rung	Checks placed here
	automated access; The site serves what its own rules permit
Access II	A published description of the agency's data service; A front door built for programs; From a data page to the data service, terms, change log and inventory; A change history a program can follow
Context I	The methods are readable as plain text
Context II	The release date, and a link to the latest release
Access III	none measured yet
Context III	none measured yet
Evaluation I	none measured yet
Evaluation II	none measured yet
Evaluation III	none measured yet

What each measured rung asks, and what comes next

Each count below is read rung by rung on its own, not as a climb: an agency can clear a level's checks and still miss a prerequisite check it was measured on, so a higher rung can show more agencies than a lower one. A check that could not be measured for an agency is left out of that rung for it, never counted as a fail.

Prerequisite, discoverable. An agency clears this rung when none of its measured checks here comes back a fail; on the cycle of record zero of sixteen did. The next rung up asks for: "Data is published in machine-readable files".

Prerequisite, clearly licensed. An agency clears this rung when none of its measured checks here comes back a fail; on the cycle of record zero of sixteen did. The next rung up asks for: "Data is published in machine-readable files".

Access I. An agency clears this rung when none of its measured checks here comes back a fail; on the cycle of record eleven of sixteen did. The next rung up asks for: "Stable, documented endpoints agents can crawl".

Access II. An agency clears this rung when none of its measured checks here comes back a fail; on the cycle of record one of sixteen did. The next rung up asks for: "Agent-native interface for live, structured queries".

Context I. An agency clears this rung when none of its measured checks here comes back a fail; on the cycle of record two of sixteen did. The next rung up asks for: "Methodology and caveats travel with each dataset".

Context II. An agency clears this rung when none of its measured checks here comes back a fail; on the cycle of record one of sixteen did. The next rung up asks for: "Context is machine-readable and citable in an answer".

What we kept, what we changed

Kept, as USAFacts wrote them: the three tracks and their names, the three levels, the three prerequisites, the SLSA shape, and the intended use. Changed, and why: Prerequisites are measured from the outside, not asked of the agency, because a prerequisite only asserted cannot anchor a level. Every check carries a measurement specification, so two agencies cannot claim the same rung for different reasons. A rung is reported per check and an agency's position is the highest rung at which every measured check passes; a check not measured is left out, never read as a fail. The Evaluation track is shown empty and said to be empty, because building its instrument is a testing-and-evaluation programme this diagnostic does not attempt.

For the record

Attached: the measurement sheet (every check as a measurement specification), the roll-up (this ladder at a glance), the sixteen-check one-pager, and DN-019 (the view ladder these reports sit on).

SI use: in these pages SI means statistical information, the data a federal statistical agency publishes for the public; the readiness described is whether a program acting for a member of the public can reach that statistical information and the documentation that travels with it. The letters AI appear only inside USAFacts' own titles and the framework captions quoted here.